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CODEX OF THE ARCANAE

*The seventy-eight cards as an instrument of reading: the
twenty-two major arcana, the four suits and the thirty-six
decans*

VILLUMINATIONS

Fine edition, 2026

Original work · First edition, 2026
villuminations.com

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CHAPTER 1

WHAT TAROT IS

This book is not going to tell you what is going to happen to you, and it is best dealt with in the first line because it is what almost everyone expects from a book on tarot.

WHAT THIS BOOK CLAIMS

Tarot is a projective instrument. Seventy-eight images rich enough and ambiguous enough for whoever looks at them to find their own situation in them, and fixed enough that they cannot find just anything. That combination —bounded ambiguity— is exactly what defines a good projective instrument, and it is the reason it works.

What happens in a spread is that a matter that was blurred meets, all at once, a repertoire of concrete figures, and in being given those figures it becomes articulate. No new information about the world appears: what appears, formulated, is the information you already had and had not said. That is a great deal, and it is not divination.

WHAT THIS BOOK DOES NOT CLAIM

- It does not claim that the cards report on the future. Nothing that follows predicts events, and no spread in this book is built to try.
- It does not claim that the order in which the cards come up is determined by anything. A shuffled deck comes out at random, and

randomness is precisely what makes the instrument useful: it forces you to look at figures you would not have chosen.

- It does not claim that tarot comes from Egypt, or from the Roma, or from any lost wisdom. Chapter 2 tells where it really comes from, with dates.
- It does not replace medical, psychological, legal or financial advice. Chapter 17 says exactly what you do not ask a deck, and it means it.

WHY KEEP THE WHOLE APPARATUS, THEN

Because the apparatus is half the instrument. The Hebrew letters, the decans, the elements, the numbers: none of that makes the cards divine anything, and all of it gives each figure a precise outline instead of letting it mean whatever suits you. A tarot without structure is an inkblot test; with structure it is a language. The difference is that a language can be learnt wrongly and corrected.



WHERE WHAT IS TAUGHT HERE COMES FROM

From the Marseille pattern, the engravings that settle in France between the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries and have been in the public domain for centuries; from Éliphas Lévi's «Transcendental Magic: Its Doctrine and Ritual», 1856, which is where the twenty-two major arcana are first tied to the twenty-two Hebrew letters; and from Papus's «The Tarot of the Bohemians», 1889, which systematises that tying. All three are free.

What is original here: the whole of the writing, the structure, the readings of the seventy-eight, the three spreads, the notebook and the five plates. And one more thing, the one that makes this book a system and not a catalogue of meanings: the tables are deduced. Each major arcanum receives its letter by position and inherits its attribution from the letter; each card from two to ten receives its decan by rule. None of that is typed in by hand, and the plate generator refuses to draw if any deduction fails to close.

THE TWO TABLES THAT HOLD UP THE WHOLE BOOK

One is the Hebrew alphabet with its division into three mother letters, seven double and twelve simple, which is what distributes the twenty-two major arcana among elements, planets and signs without anyone having to decide it. The other is the thirty-six decans of the zodiac, which distribute the thirty-six cards from two to ten. Neither of the two is typed in: they are deduced and checked, and if one fails to close the book is not typeset.

CHAPTER 2

THE REAL HISTORY

The history tarot tells about itself is false, and the true one is more interesting. It deserves a chapter because knowing where a tool comes from is part of knowing how to use it.

WHAT THE DATES SAY

A CHRONOLOGY OF THE VERIFIABLE

THE 1440S	In northern Italy —Milan, Ferrara, Bologna— the first decks appear with trump cards added to an ordinary pack. They are called <i>trionfi</i> and they are a card game, expensive and hand-painted.
SIXTEENTH CENTURY	The game spreads. The word «tarocchi» replaces «trionfi». There is not a single mention of divination in two hundred years of documents.
SEVENTEENTH– EIGHTEENTH CENTURIES	The pattern we now call Marseille settles in France: the same twenty-two trumps, with the same names and in the same order, woodcut and cheap.
1781	Antoine Court de Gébelin publishes an essay claiming that tarot is a surviving Egyptian book. He offers no evidence at all. That is the moment everything else is born.
1780–1790	Etteilla turns that idea into a trade and publishes the first method of cartomantic reading.
1856	Éliphas Lévi ties the twenty-two major arcana to the twenty-two Hebrew letters. It is the decisive structural contribution, and it is a nineteenth-century invention, not an ancient tradition.
1889	Papus systematises the whole in a book that remains the continental reference.

THE TWO CONSEQUENCES OF KNOWING THIS

The first is a matter of honesty: anyone selling you tarot as millennia-old Egyptian wisdom is repeating, without knowing it, a claim a French scholar made without evidence in 1781. The decks are European, Renaissance, and they started out as a parlour game.

The second is more useful and rather liberating: if tarot's symbolic structure was built in the nineteenth century, then it is a deliberate construction, made by people who knew what they were doing and to a criterion that can be examined. And an examinable construction is infinitely more usable than a revelation. It can be learnt, argued with, and corrected where it fails.

WHAT IS GENUINELY OLD

The material Lévi built with. The twenty-two letters and their division come from the «Sefer Yetzirah», earlier than the year one thousand. The four elements and the thirty-six decans come from Hellenistic astrology, second century. The trump figures —Death, the Wheel of Fortune, Temperance— are ordinary medieval iconography, the kind found in churches and in books. The material is old; the assembly is modern. And the assembly is good.

CHAPTER 3

THE STRUCTURE OF THE SEVENTY-EIGHT

Before a single reading, the architecture. A tarot deck is not seventy-eight loose cards; it is two systems fitted together, and confusing them is the beginner's first mistake.



PL. 1 The seventy-eight. Above, the twenty-two major arcana as a single series. Below, the four suits, each with its ace, its nine numerals and its four court cards.

THE TWO SYSTEMS

22 MAJOR ARCANA

A series numbered I to XXI plus The Fool. There are no suits and no repetitions: each one is unique and occupies a place on a journey.

56 MINOR ARCANA

Four suits of fourteen cards: ace, two to ten, and four court cards. The structure of an ordinary pack, with one extra court card.

WHAT EACH HALF DOES

The major arcana speak of processes: stages, thresholds, changes of state. They are few and large, and when they come up in a spread they indicate that what is at stake is not a circumstance but a stretch of the road.

The minor arcana speak of circumstances: the concrete, the everyday, what is happening this week in an identifiable area of life. They are many and small, and that is why a spread of minors alone describes a situation and a spread loaded with majors describes a moment.

THE PROPORTION AS A READING IN ITSELF

With twenty-two majors in seventy-eight cards, the expected proportion is a little under three in every ten. If six majors come up in a ten-card spread, that is already information before reading any of them: the matter runs deeper than the question assumed. And if not one comes up in a question that seemed vital, that is information too: it probably was not that vital.

THE NUMBER OF CARDS AND WHY IT IS THAT ONE

Twenty-two is not an accident: they are the letters of the Hebrew alphabet, and that fit is what Lévi found and what made tarot a system. Nor is fifty-six: it is four times fourteen, and fourteen is ten plus four — the ten stages of number and the four court cards. The total, seventy-eight, is also the sum of the first twelve numbers, which is the kind of coincidence the builders of the system loved and which means nothing in itself.

CHAPTER 4

THE MAJOR ARCANA AND THEIR LETTERS

The chapter that explains where the entries in the next four come from. It is the technical part and it is worth reading first, because afterwards it is not explained again.

N.º	ARCANUM	LETTER	RULES	N.º	ARCANUM	LETTER	RULES
I	The Magician	Aleph	Air	XII	The Hanged Man	Lamed	Libra
II	The High Priestess	Beth	Saturn	XIII	The Nameless Arcanum	Mem	Water
III	The Empress	Gimel	Jupiter	XIV	Temperance	Nun	Scorpio
IV	The Emperor	Daleth	Mars	XV	The Devil	Samekh	Sagittarius
V	The Hierophant	He	Aries	XVI	The Tower	Ayin	Capricorn
VI	The Lovers	Vav	Taurus	XVII	The Star	Pe	Venus
VII	The Chariot	Zayin	Gemini	XVIII	The Moon	Tzaddi	Aquarius
VIII	Justice	Cheth	Cancer	XIX	The Sun	Qoph	Pisces
IX	The Hermit	Teth	Leo	XX	Judgement	Resh	Mercury
X	The Wheel	Yod	Virgo	XXI	The World	Shin	Fire
XI	Strength	Kaph	Sun	☐	The Fool	Tav	Moon

I WITH ALEPH · XXI WITH SHIN · THE FOOL CLOSES WITH TAV

PL. 2 The twenty-two with their letter, their numerical value and what they rule. The colour says which class the letter belongs to: yellow the three mothers, orange the seven doubles, blue the twelve simples.

THE DIVISION THIS BOOK USES

Arcanum I goes with the first letter, II with the second, and so on to XXI with the twenty-first. The Fool, which carries no number or carries zero, closes the series with the letter that is left. It is Lévi's and Papus's division, the continental one, and it is chosen for two reasons: it is the older of the two that exist, and it fits exactly with the Hebrew alphabet's division into three mothers, seven doubles and twelve simples.

That fit is what makes each arcanum inherit an attribution without anyone having to decide it: three of the twenty-two rule an element, seven rule a planet and twelve rule a sign. It is not assigned: it is deduced.

THE THREE ELEMENTAL MAJORS

I · THE MAGICIAN	Aleph · Air. The first of the series rules the element of breath and of the word, which is what a magician works with.
XIII · THE NAMELESS ARCANUM	Mem · Water. The arcanum of transformation rules the element that dissolves.
XXI · THE WORLD	Shin · Fire. The last numbered one rules the element that consummates.

THE OTHER DIVISION, AND WHY IT IS NOT USED HERE

The English tradition of the late nineteenth century begins the series with The Fool on the first letter and shifts everything else along one place, besides swapping Justice and Strength between VIII and XI. It is a coherent and very widespread system, and if you learnt with it everything in this book remains usable: only the letter column changes. What you cannot do is mix the two, and that is why one is chosen here and kept from beginning to end. This book uses the Marseille order: Justice at VIII and Strength at XI.

HOW TO READ THE ENTRIES IN THE FOLLOWING CHAPTERS

- «Letter» gives the name, the numerical value and the class. The value is the one gematria uses; the class is the one that decides which family of attribution falls to it.
- «Rules» is the inherited element, planet or sign. It is not an ornament: it is what gives the card a precise outline instead of an elastic meaning.
- «The image» describes in words the picture of the Marseille pattern. It is described and not reproduced, because this book draws its own.
- Then come three paragraphs: what the card says upright, what it says reversed, and the question it poses. The question is the useful part.

CHAPTER 5

FROM I TO VI · THE SETTING OUT

The first six arcana describe the kit you set out with: the capacity to act, to know, to create, to order, to learn and to choose.

I · THE MAGICIAN

LETTER	Aleph · value 1 · mother · element
RULES	Air
THE IMAGE	A man standing before a table of assorted objects, one hand up and the other down.

Upright: you have the means and you have not started yet. It is the card of the one who can, and that is why it is the most uncomfortable of the twenty-two: it does not accept the excuse of lacking resources. The table is laid.

Reversed: skill without direction. A great deal of talent spread over too many things, or dexterity used to impress instead of to make. Also the charlatan, who is the magician who stopped at the gesture.

The question: What could you already do today with what is on your table?

II · THE HIGH PRIESTESS

LETTER	Beth · value 2 · double · planet
RULES	Saturn
THE IMAGE	A seated figure, a half-open book on her lap, between two columns.

Upright: there is something you know and have not said, or that you would know if you stayed still for a while. It is the card of knowledge that is not displayed and of the one who waits for the moment. Against the Magician, who acts, she reads.

Reversed: reserve turned into a useless secret. Keeping out of habit what there is no longer any reason to keep, or mistaking silence for depth.

The question: What do you know about this that you have not yet put into words?

III · THE EMPRESS

LETTER	Gimel · value 3 · double · planet
RULES	Jupiter
THE IMAGE	A seated woman with sceptre and shield, looking to one side.

Upright: something is growing and needs tending. It is the card of the fertile and of what gets made by tending rather than forcing. Also concrete abundance: what there is, not what is hoped for.

Reversed: growth with no channel, or care that suffocates. Overprotecting a project or a person to the point of preventing them from growing on their own.

The question: What is growing here, and am I tending it or watching over it?

IV · THE EMPEROR

LETTER	Daleth · value 4 · double · planet
RULES	Mars
THE IMAGE	A man seated in profile, legs crossed and holding a sceptre.

Upright: structure is needed and it is needed now. A frame, a limit, a decision that puts what is scattered in order. It is the least poetic card in the deck and one of the most necessary.

Reversed: rigidity, or authority sustained by habit and not by judgement. The frame that was put up to protect something and now prevents it.

The question: What here needs a structure, and who is going to provide it?

V · THE HIEROPHANT

LETTER	He · value 5 · simple · sign
RULES	Aries
THE IMAGE	A figure with mitre and staff, two smaller people before him.

Upright: there is something to be learnt from someone, or something to pass on. It is the card of teaching and of the shared frame — tradition, the rule, what is inherited. When it comes up in a spread it usually indicates that it is worth consulting before deciding.

Reversed: dogma. Repeating a rule because it is the rule, or looking for a master so as not to have to decide. Also the guide who has grown used to being believed.

The question: Whom should I ask, and what is stopping me from asking them?

VI · THE LOVERS

LETTER	Vav · value 6 · simple · sign
RULES	Taurus
THE IMAGE	A young man between two figures, and above them a third with a bow.

Upright: a choice has to be made, and choosing means losing one of the two. It is not the card of love: it is the card of the crossroads, and in the Marseille pattern the young man is literally looking to one side.

Reversed: the choice that never gets made. Staying at the crossroads so as to give up nothing, which is the most expensive way of giving up both.

The question: What is the choice I have been putting off, and what do I lose with each option?

CHAPTER 6

FROM VII TO XII · THE TRIAL

The next six are no longer equipment: they are the trials. What happens once the road is under way and stops depending on what you brought with you.

VII · THE CHARIOT

LETTER	Zayin · value 7 · simple · sign
RULES	Gemini
THE IMAGE	A crowned man on a chariot drawn by two horses heading in different directions.

Upright: you advance, and you advance by hauling on two forces that do not quite go in the same direction. It is the card of control achieved by effort and of progress that has to be held by hand.

Reversed: the chariot stops or veers off. Internal forces going their own way, or a victory won and not used.

The question: What are the two forces I am hauling at once, and where is each one going?

VIII · JUSTICE

LETTER	Cheth · value 8 · simple · sign
RULES	Cancer
THE IMAGE	A seated woman, a sword in one hand and a set of scales in the other.

Upright: you have to measure and you have to decide on what you measured. It is the card of consequence: what was done has effects and they need counting. Also the fair agreement, the contract, what gets put in writing.

Reversed: the scales tilted. Judging without data, or asking for justice while expecting it to coincide with what you want.

The question: Am I really measuring this, or am I looking for it to prove me right?

IX · THE HERMIT

LETTER	Teth · value 9 · simple · sign
RULES	Leo
THE IMAGE	A hooded old man with a lantern and a staff, walking.

Upright: it is time to withdraw for a stretch. Not to flee: to see. It is the card of the one who carries his own light and advances slowly, and it tends to come up when what is needed is less consultation and more silence.

Reversed: isolation. The withdrawal that stopped being an instrument and became an address, with the sense of superiority that usually comes with it.

The question: What would I see of this if I stepped away for a week?

X · THE WHEEL

LETTER	Yod · value 10 · simple · sign
RULES	Virgo
THE IMAGE	A wheel with figures rising on one side and falling on the other.

Upright: this changes and it does not depend on you. It is the card of the cycle and of chance, and its lesson is one of the hard ones: there is a stretch of the matter that admits nothing but waiting well. It connects with the oldest and most useful distinction in practical philosophy: the one that separates what depends on us from what does not.

Reversed: fighting the wheel. Pushing against a cycle, or claiming credit for a rise that belonged to the turn itself.

The question: What part of this is turning on its own, and what am I doing to brake it?

XI · STRENGTH

LETTER	Kaph · value 20 · double · planet
RULES	Sun
THE IMAGE	A woman opening a lion's jaws with her hands, with no apparent violence.

Upright: the strength that serves here is not the kind that strikes. It is the kind that holds without yielding and without fighting, day after day. The card of constancy and of a self-command that needs no demonstrating.

Reversed: strength spent on mastering what cannot be mastered, or restraint that has become repression. Also the softness that calls itself patience.

The question: What am I trying to subdue instead of hold?

XII · THE HANGED MAN

LETTER	Lamed · value 30 · simple · sign
RULES	Libra
THE IMAGE	A man suspended by one foot from a beam, head down and untroubled.

Upright: waiting that means something. It is the card of the change of viewpoint bought by paying the discomfort of staying still in an awkward position. Nothing advances, and that is the right thing now.

Reversed: useless sacrifice. Enduring for the sake of enduring, or hanging there waiting for a rescue that is nobody's to give. Also the martyr, who is the hanged man who has started charging for it.

The question: Is this waiting doing anything, or is it only costing me?

CHAPTER 7

FROM XIII TO XVIII · THE PASSAGE

The hard stretch. Six arcana describing what collapses, what gets ordered afterwards and what is badly seen in the dark.

XIII · THE NAMELESS ARCANUM

LETTER	Mem · value 40 · mother · element
RULES	Water
THE IMAGE	A skeleton with a scythe, reaping. In the Marseille pattern this card carries no written name.

Upright: something is ending, and ending is its function. It is not the card of physical death: it is the card of the cut, of the ending that clears the ground. That it carries no name in Marseille is the best clue to how to read it.

Reversed: the ending that is not allowed to happen. Keeping alive something that already finished, with the cost that carries. Also fear of change turned into a regime.

The question: What has ended here that I keep treating as alive?

XIV · TEMPERANCE

LETTER	Nun · value 50 · simple · sign
RULES	Scorpio
THE IMAGE	A winged figure pouring liquid between two vessels without spilling a drop.

Upright: mixing well and in the right proportion. After the cut comes the fine work of putting back together, and it is done slowly. It is the card of measure and of technical patience.

Reversed: the mixture that will not take, or excess disguised as balance. Also lukewarmness, which is not temperance but a lack of judgement.

The question: What proportion should this be in, and what proportion is it in?

XV · THE DEVIL

LETTER	Samekh · value 60 · simple · sign
RULES	Sagittarius
THE IMAGE	A horned figure on a pedestal, with two smaller figures tied to it by the neck with slack ropes.

Upright: there is an attachment that binds, and the rope is slack. It is the most misread card in the deck: it does not speak of evil, it speaks of

what you hold on to knowing that it holds you. What makes it uncomfortable is the rope: it could be taken off.

Reversed: the bond is starting to loosen, or its existence is being denied. And the most effective way of denying it is to talk a great deal about freedom.

The question: What am I tied to by a rope I could take off, and what do I gain by staying?

XVI · THE TOWER

LETTER	Ayin · value 70 · simple · sign
RULES	Capricorn
THE IMAGE	A tower struck from above, with two figures falling from it.

Upright: what was built on a false assumption falls, and it falls all at once. It is a hard card and it is not a bad card: what collapses here would have collapsed anyway, later and more expensively.

Reversed: the collapse has been postponed by propping the tower up. It works, and every prop makes the ending dearer.

The question: What am I propping up that is going to fall anyway?

XVII · THE STAR

LETTER	Pe · value 80 · double · planet
RULES	Venus
THE IMAGE	A naked figure kneeling by the water, pouring from two jugs, with stars above.

Upright: after the tower, this. It is the card of slow repair with no audience: you empty out what you had, you let it run, and your bearings come back. The most serene of the twenty-two.

Reversed: hope without work, or the discouragement that settles in when repair does not go as fast as one would like.

The question: What would I have to empty out here for something to start running?

XVIII · THE MOON

LETTER	Tsade · value 90 · simple · sign
RULES	Aquarius
THE IMAGE	Two dogs howling at the moon beside a pool out of which a crayfish is climbing, between two towers.

Upright: perception is not reliable right now. It is the card of what is badly seen in half-light: fears that grow, intuitions that hit the mark and cannot be justified, memory that rewrites. You do not decide under this card; you wait.

Reversed: the fog is lifting, or what was imagination is being taken for evidence. In a spread about another person, reversed it usually indicates that the information you have is second-hand.

The question: What of this do I know, and what am I imagining?

CHAPTER 8

FROM XIX TO XXI AND THE FOOL · THE WAY OUT

The last three numbered ones and the one with no number. What lies after the passage, and the one who starts over.

XIX · THE SUN

LETTER	Qoph · value 100 · simple · sign
RULES	Pisces
THE IMAGE	Two figures together beneath a sun with a face and straight rays.

Upright: you see clearly and you see with someone else. It is the card of the shared obvious: the matter is understood, it can be said out loud and it needs no explaining. After the Moon, it is literally daybreak.

Reversed: clarity turned into display, or light that dazzles and hides the detail. Also the cheerfulness that allows no shading.

The question: What is clear here that I have not yet said out loud?

XX · JUDGEMENT

LETTER	Resh · value 200 · double · planet
RULES	Mercury
THE IMAGE	Figures rising from the ground at the sound of a trumpet blown from above.

Upright: there is a call and it has to be answered. It is the card of the decision that had been put off and of the awakening one does not choose. It tends to come up when the matter is already settled inside and only the acting is left.

Reversed: the call that is heard and not answered. And its commonest form: acknowledging that something must be done and settling down to research the subject a little more.

The question: What is it that I already know I have to do?

XXI · THE WORLD

LETTER	Shin · value 300 · mother · element
RULES	Fire
THE IMAGE	A figure inside a laurel wreath, with the four images of the evangelists in the corners.

Upright: it is complete. The four elements in the four corners and the centre occupied: the work closes and the closing shows in the concrete world. It is the card of what is finished and of what is integrated.

Reversed: the closing that never arrives, or the one declared too soon. Also the finished work that is not let go of.

The question: What exactly is missing before this can be called closed?

0 · THE FOOL

LETTER	Tav · value 400 · double · planet
RULES	Moon
THE IMAGE	A walker with a bundle over his shoulder and a dog biting his leg, walking on without looking.

Upright: you set off with no guarantees and no number. The Fool is not in the series: he crosses it. It is the card of the beginning that does not justify itself, of freedom with no fixed place and of the one who does not yet know what he is getting into — which is the only way of getting into anything new.

Reversed: irresponsibility. Setting off without looking out of habit, or turning the absence of commitment into an identity.

The question: What would I begin if I did not have to justify it to anyone?



THE COMPLETE JOURNEY, IN ONE LINE

From I to VI the kit is gathered; from VII to XII it is tested; from XIII to XVIII it collapses and is put back together; from XIX to XXI it closes. And The Fool comes and goes wherever he likes, which is what having no number means. When a spread brings several majors, that order says which stretch of the road the matter is in — and it is usually one stretch earlier than the querent thought.

CHAPTER 9

THE FOUR SUITS

The minor arcana are organised by suit, and each suit is an element and a faculty. Knowing that, half the meaning of each card is already in place before you look at the number.

			
WANDS	CUPS	SWORDS	PENTACLES
Fire	Water	Air	Earth
● Page Earth ● Knight Air ● Queen Water ● King Fire	● Page Earth ● Knight Air ● Queen Water ● King Fire	● Page Earth ● Knight Air ● Queen Water ● King Fire	● Page Earth ● Knight Air ● Queen Water ● King Fire

EACH COURT CARD CARRIES ITS OWN ELEMENT WITHIN THE SUIT

PL. 3 The four suits with their element and their four court cards. Each court card also carries its own element within the suit, and from that come the sixteen combinations.

THE FOUR SUITS

WANDS · FIRE

Will and enterprise. What is undertaken, driven and defended. Area of life: projects, one's own work, initiative.

CUPS · WATER

Feeling and the bond. What is felt, remembered and shared. Area: relationships, family, states of mind.

SWORDS · AIR

Thought and the word. What is decided, argued and cut. Area: decisions, conflicts, communication.

PENTACLES · EARTH

The body and the concrete. What is sustained, produced and counted. Area: money, health, home, employed work.

THE ARGUMENT ABOUT THE SWORDS

There is an old dispute about whether the Swords are Air or Fire, and the Wands the other way round. The argument of those who make them Fire is that a sword is forged; that of those who make them Air—the majority view since the nineteenth century and the one this book uses—is that a sword cuts and distinguishes, which is what thought does. It is said here because if you read another book and it does not agree, you now know why.

THE FOUR COURT CARDS AND THE ELEMENT INSIDE THE ELEMENT

Each suit has four court cards, and each court card carries its own element. The King is the fire of the suit, the Queen its water, the Knight

its air and the Page its earth. From that come sixteen combinations describing ways of being in an area, not people.

HOW A COURT CARD IS READ

KING	Fire of the suit. Commands and decides in that area. The version that leads.
QUEEN	Water of the suit. Sustains and nourishes that area from within. The version that cares.
KNIGHT	Air of the suit. Moves, travels, fetches and carries. The version that acts outwards.
PAGE	Earth of the suit. Learns, begins, receives. The version that studies.

The King of Pentacles is the fire of earth: the one who directs the concrete. The Page of Swords is the earth of air: the one who is learning to think. With the two coordinates —suit and court card— the sixteen are deduced and need no memorising.

THE COURT CARDS ARE NOT PEOPLE

The commonest mistake with the sixteen is reading them as «someone». Sometimes they are, and almost always they are a way of being: the querent acting as Page when it is time to act as King, or as King when they ought to be learning. Asking «who is this card» closes the reading; asking «where am I acting from» opens it.

CHAPTER 10

THE ACES AND THE TEN STAGES

The four aces and the scale from one to ten, which is what turns forty cards into a system instead of a list.

THE FOUR ACES

The ace is not the number one: it is the pure element, the root of the suit before it shows itself in anything concrete. When it comes up in a spread it indicates that the matter is at its source and has no form yet — and that form is available to it.

THE FOUR SOURCES

ACE OF WANDS	Raw fire. An impulse that is not yet a project. The appetite.
ACE OF CUPS	Raw water. A feeling before it has an object. The opening.
ACE OF SWORDS	Raw air. An idea before it has an argument. The clarity that cuts.
ACE OF PENTACLES	Raw earth. A resource before it is spent. Material possibility.

THE TEN STAGES OF NUMBER

From two to ten, each number describes a stage of the same process, whatever the suit. Learn the scale once and it serves for all thirty-six.

THE SCALE, FROM TWO TO TEN

TWO	The first relation and the first tension. Two things face to face: balance or choice.
THREE	What resolves the two: a third appears, a synthesis, an initial result.
FOUR	Stability achieved. It consolidates, and with it begins the risk of settling.
FIVE	The break. The four breaks because it had to break: it is the number of crisis in all four suits.
SIX	The putting back together after the five. Balance is recovered, this time with information.
SEVEN	The individual test. What was recovered has to be held alone, and the temptation to let go appears.
EIGHT	Movement and craft. You work, you speed up, you make quantity.
NINE	The result almost closed, with what it cost in plain sight. The most ambivalent number on the scale.
TEN	The end of the cycle: brimming or exhausted, depending on the suit. What comes next is another ace.

WHAT THE SCALE IS REALLY FOR

That the fives are crises in all four suits and the tens are endings in all four. When two fives come up in a spread, you need to know nothing else to say that the matter is at breaking point. The scale is what lets you read a card you do not remember: number plus suit, and out it comes.

CHAPTER 11

THE THIRTY-SIX AND THEIR DECANS

Here is the piece that gives tarot its finest layer of precision. The thirty-six cards from two to ten are not thirty-six loose meanings: they are the thirty-six decans of the zodiac, one per card, with none left over and none missing.

		0° – 10°	10° – 20°	20° – 30°
	Aries	 2 of Wands	 3 of Wands	 4 of Wands
	Taurus	 5 of Pentacles	 6 of Pentacles	 7 of Pentacles
	Gemini	 8 of Swords	 9 of Swords	 10 of Swords
	Cancer	 2 of Cups	 3 of Cups	 4 of Cups
	Leo	 5 of Wands	 6 of Wands	 7 of Wands
	Virgo	 8 of Pentacles	 9 of Pentacles	 10 of Pentacles
	Libra	 2 of Swords	 3 of Swords	 4 of Swords
	Scorpio	 5 of Cups	 6 of Cups	 7 of Cups
	Sagittarius	 8 of Wands	 9 of Wands	 10 of Wands
	Capricorn	 2 of Pentacles	 3 of Pentacles	 4 of Pentacles
	Aquarius	 5 of Swords	 6 of Swords	 7 of Swords
	Pisces	 8 of Cups	 9 of Cups	 10 of Cups
THE SUIT COMES FROM THE ELEMENT · THE NUMBER, THE MODE				

PL. 4 The thirty-six. Each row is a sign with its three stretches of ten degrees, and in each stretch the card that corresponds to it. Not one card repeated, not one decan empty.

THE RULE, WHICH IS THE BEAUTIFUL PART

The distribution does not have to be memorised because it is deduced from two criteria.

- 1 The suit comes from the element of the sign. Aries is Fire, so its three decans are Wands. Taurus is Earth: Pentacles. And so on for all twelve.

- 2 The trio of numbers comes from the mode. Cardinal signs take the two, the three and the four; fixed signs the five, the six and the seven; mutable signs the eight, the nine and the ten.
- 3 Within the sign, the first decan goes to the first number of the trio, the second to the second and the third to the third.
- 4 And the ruler of each decan comes from the Chaldean order beginning at Mars, which is the classical distribution and the one that closes without leaving gaps.

A COMPLETE EXAMPLE

ARIES	Cardinal fire → Wands, trio 2-3-4
2 OF WANDS	Aries 0° to 10° · ruler Mars · the impulse with no filter
3 OF WANDS	Aries 10° to 20° · ruler Sun · the impulse with direction
4 OF WANDS	Aries 20° to 30° · ruler Venus · the impulse that seeks company

WHY THIS CLOSSES WITH NOTHING LEFT OVER

Four elements times three modes are twelve signs, and no cell repeats. Twelve signs times three decans are thirty-six. Four suits times nine numbers—from two to ten—are thirty-six as well. The two grids are the same size and fit into each other without a gap. That they fit is not a fortunate coincidence: it is that whoever assembled the system in the nineteenth century counted first.

WHAT IS GAINED BY READING THIS WAY

Precision, and a bridge. The six of Cups will stop being «nostalgia» —which is what most manuals say— and will be Scorpio in its second decan, ruled by the Sun: intensity with a purpose. It is a more specific reading, harder to stretch to suit, and with a table behind it that can be checked.

And the bridge works both ways. If you also work with astrology, each decan now has a card that represents it; if you work with tarot, each minor card now has thirty degrees of zodiac and a ruling planet behind it. The two subjects read better together, and that is deliberate.

AND THE USUAL HONESTY

This correspondence is a nineteenth-century construction, elegant and coherent, and not the revelation of a real link between pieces of card and degrees of sky. Its value is that of any good classification system: it gives each element a unique place and makes reasoning possible. That is enough, and it is a great deal.

HOW A READING ACTUALLY WORKS

The chapter most manuals skip, because it explains the mechanism and explaining it looks like taking the magic away. The opposite happens: once the mechanism is understood, the reading improves a great deal.

WHAT HAPPENS IN A SPREAD

- 1** A question is formulated. The mere fact of having to formulate it already forces a blurred matter into focus, and part of the spread's yield is produced here, before the deck is touched.
- 2** A fixed number of cards is drawn into positions with assigned meanings. Chance supplies the figures; the structure of the spread supplies the role of each one.
- 3** You look at what comes up and search for how it fits. This is the step where the work happens: the mind projects the situation onto the figure and, in doing so, articulates what it knew and had not said.
- 4** You say it out loud or write it down. Without this step the spread dissolves: what is not formulated does not stay.

WHY CHANCE IS INDISPENSABLE

Because the instrument's value lies in putting figures in front of you that you would not have chosen. If you chose the cards, you would

choose the ones that confirm what you already think — and there would be no spread, there would be a mirror. Chance is what guarantees the discomfort, and the discomfort is what produces the finding.

THE OBVIOUS OBJECTION, ANSWERED

«If it is chance, then any card would do for anything.» No: that would happen if the cards had no outline. This book's apparatus —letters, elements, decans, the scale of number— exists precisely so that each figure means something fairly specific and does not admit just any reading. When a card does not fit what you want to hear, the structure stops you stretching it, and that is where the instrument does its best work.

THE THREE RULES OF THE GOOD READER

- You read what is there, not what was expected. If the spread says nothing, you say it says nothing. A reader who always finds a message is manufacturing them.
- You read the whole before the cards. How many majors, which suits dominate, which numbers repeat: that says more than any individual card, and it is seen in five seconds.
- You finish with a concrete action. A spread that ends in a pretty interpretation has been no use. One that ends in «I am going to say this to this person this week» has.

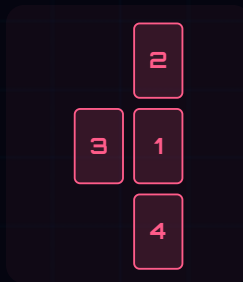
CHAPTER 13

THE SPREADS

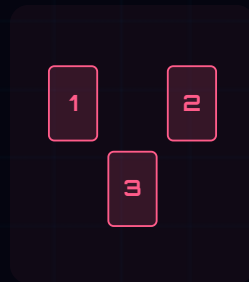
Three spreads, designed for this book and thought out for what the instrument actually does. None of the three asks about the future.



THE THREE



THE CROSS OF FOUR



THE MIRROR

What was · what is · what is missing · what I bring · what hides itself · what the other sees it · what neither

THREE SPREADS OF OUR OWN · NONE PREDICTS ANYTHING

PL. 5 The three layouts with the order in which each card is drawn.

THE THREE

The basic one, three cards in a row. It is the one used ninety per cent of the time and the one worth mastering before any other.

THE THREE · POSITIONS

1 · WHAT WAS THERE	The real starting point of the matter, not the one that gets told.
2 · WHAT IS THERE	The situation as it stands now.
3 · WHAT IS MISSING	What has not been put in yet. Not what will happen: what is missing.

THE CROSS OF FOUR

For when there is a decision to be made and nothing is moving. The third position is usually the one that resolves the spread.

THE CROSS OF FOUR · POSITIONS

1 · THE FACT	In the centre. What is really happening, with no interpretation.
2 · WHAT I BRING	Above. What I have going for me in this.
3 · WHAT HINDERS	On the left. And it is usually something of one's own.
4 · THE STEP	Below. The concrete action called for now.

THE MIRROR

The most uncomfortable and the most useful in conflicts with another person. Three cards.

THE MIRROR · POSITIONS

1 · AS I SEE IT

My version of the matter.

2 · AS THE OTHER SEES IT

Their version. This card is read all the way through before being argued with.

3 · WHAT NEITHER SEES

The shared blind spot. It is the position that justifies the spread.

ON THE MIRROR'S SECOND POSITION

It does not report what the other person thinks: there is no way a deck could know that. What it does is force you to build their version out of material you did not choose, and that produces an exercise in perspective that spontaneous reflection almost never produces. It is the same logic as any structured examination of conscience, with different tools.

THE RULE ABOUT THE NUMBER OF CARDS

Few. Three or four for almost everything, and never more than seven. A spread of ten or eleven cards gives so much information that any story at all can be built from it, and there the instrument is lost. The constraint is what forces precision — the same reason a good diagnosis uses few well-chosen tests.

CHAPTER 14

THE REVERSED CARD

A short chapter on a question that divides readers and is worth settling before you start, because you have to choose and stick to it.

THE TWO SCHOOLS

WITH REVERSALS AND WITHOUT

WITH REVERSALS

Each card has two readings according to its orientation. It doubles the vocabulary to 156 positions and sharpens things considerably, at the cost of complicating the learning.

WITHOUT REVERSALS

All cards are read upright and the nuance comes from the neighbouring cards. Simpler, and some very good readers use nothing else.

This book works with reversals, and gives the reversed reading of the twenty-two majors in chapters 5 to 8. It is chosen this way because a reversed card forces you to look at the uncomfortable side of the figure, and that side is precisely the one an indulgent reader skips.

THE FOUR WAYS OF READING A REVERSAL

- Excess. The same quality taken too far: Strength that has become stubbornness, Temperance that has become lukewarmness. It is the

commonest reading and the one that almost always works.

- Deficiency. The quality that is missing or falls short: the Emperor reversed as an absence of structure.
- Blockage. The card's energy exists and does not circulate. Very useful in «what hinders» positions.
- Inwardness. What the card describes is happening inside and has not shown itself. It is the least used reading and the subtlest.

THE RULE FOR NOT CHEATING

Choose in advance which of the four readings you are going to use in that spread and do not change it halfway. If you let yourself pick whichever fits each card best, the reversal stops meaning anything: it becomes a wild card. Noting in the notebook which reading was used is what lets you check, months later, whether you were reading or improvising.

THE READER'S MISTAKES

Predictable, and all eight cost years apiece.

- 1** Memorising seventy-eight meanings. It is unnecessary and it does not work: with the suit, the number and the scale from chapter 10, almost all of them are deduced. Whoever memorises does not know how to read, they know how to recite.
- 2** Asking about the future. It is what the instrument does not do, and forcing it produces readings that cannot be checked — so you never learn from your mistakes.
- 3** Repeating the spread. Drawing other cards because you did not like the first ones. It is the equivalent of repeating a blood test until it comes out right, and it is the clearest sign that you were not asking: you were asking for permission.
- 4** Reading for others before knowing how to read for yourself. Three hundred of your own spreads, recorded, before touching anyone else's business. Without exception.
- 5** Always finding a message. There are spreads that say nothing, and saying so is what separates a reader from a fortune teller. The honesty of admitting it is the credential of the trade.

- 6 Interpreting without looking at the whole. You count the majors, you see which suit dominates and which numbers repeat BEFORE reading a single card.
- 7 Not closing on an action. A spread with no concrete action at the end is entertainment with an esoteric vocabulary.
- 8 Not writing. Without a notebook there is no way of knowing whether your readings hold up, and therefore no way of improving. You have spent years reading, not learning.

THE REALITY CHECK

Take ten spreads from six months ago out of your notebook and read them without looking at what you wrote. If today's interpretation does not resemble the one from back then, you were improvising. If it does, you have a method. It is an unpleasant test and it is the only one there is.

WHAT YOU DO NOT ASK

The chapter on the ethics of the trade, and the most important in the book if you ever read for another person. There are five prohibitions and none of them is negotiable.

THE FIVE

HEALTH	You do not diagnose, you do not give a prognosis and you do not offer an opinion on a treatment. Ever. If someone consults you about a symptom, the answer is a single sentence: a doctor looks at that.
DEATH	You do not ask when anyone is going to die, neither the querent nor a third party. Arcanum XIII does not talk about that and neither do you.
ABSENT THIRD PARTIES	You do not read about the private life of someone who is not present and has not given permission. What you can read is the querent's position in relation to that person, which is a different thing and considerably more useful.
LEGAL MATTERS AND MONEY	You do not advise on a lawsuit, a contract or an investment. A lawyer and an adviser look at that, and getting it wrong there has consequences a reader cannot take on.
PREGNANCY AND IRREVERSIBLE DECISIONS	Not touched. No decision that cannot be undone rests on a spread.

AND A SIXTH, ABOUT THE QUERENT'S STATE

If the person consulting is in acute crisis —recent bereavement, a break-up of days ago, high anxiety, thoughts of self-harm— you do not read for them. Not because tarot is dangerous, but because in that state any ambiguous figure is read in the worst possible way, and because what that person needs is something else and you are delaying it. The correct response is to stay with them and point towards professional help.

HOW TO SAY NO

With no mystery and no airs: «this is not something you read with cards». If they insist, you repeat it the same way. A reader who accepts any question so as not to disappoint ends up doing harm, and will do it without noticing — because the consequences of a bad reading almost never come back to the person who gave it.

**The rule that sums up the six:
tarot serves to order what the querent already knows.
Never to replace what they do not know
and have to ask someone else.**

THE SPREAD NOTEBOOK

If you keep only one practice from this book, keep this one. The reason is simple and admits no argument: without a written record there is no way of knowing whether anything works.

WHY IT MATTERS MORE IN TAROT THAN ANYWHERE

Because card reading is the most fertile ground there is for self-deception. An ambiguous spread interpreted after the fact always looks as though it got it right: memory selects what fitted and discards the rest without warning. The notebook is the only antidote, and it works for a very simple reason: what was written before cannot be rewritten afterwards.

ONE ENTRY PER SPREAD

DATE AND TIME

Verbatim, as it was asked. With no tidying up afterwards

SPREAD

The Three · Cross of Four · The Mirror · other

THE CARDS

By position, with their orientation

THE WHOLE

How many majors · which suit dominates · repeated numbers

THE READING

Four lines at most. If it does not fit in four, you did not have it clear

THE ACTION

What I am going to do in the next seven days

REVIEW

Left BLANK. Filled in after four weeks

THE REVIEW BOX IS THE WHOLE METHOD

Four weeks later you go back to the entry and note down, without mercy, what happened: whether the action was carried out, whether the reading turned out to be pertinent or whether it was decoration. Fifty entries with their review filled in are worth more than five hundred spreads without it, and they are the only way of discovering that there are cards you have been reading wrongly for years.

THE QUARTERLY REVIEW

- 1 Count the spreads done and the reviews filled in. The second number is the one that matters.

- 2 Count how many actions were actually carried out. Below half, you are not reading: you are consulting.
- 3 Look for the card that has come up most. There is almost always one, and it almost always points to a matter you have left unresolved.
- 4 Look for the reading that turned out most wrong and note down why. This point is the one that produces the learning.

CHAPTER 18

THE YEAR OF PRACTICE

A twelve-month plan. It is optional and it is better than improvising.

THE FOUR QUARTERS

MONTHS 1-3

Only the twenty-two majors, separated from the rest of the deck. One card a day, drawn in the morning, read in three lines and reviewed at night. Ninety entries.

MONTHS 4-6

The four suits are added, with the scale of number. One spread of The Three a week, with a review at four weeks.

MONTHS 7-9

The decans are added: each minor card is also read by its sign and its ruler. This is where it is worth having the table of decans and rulers from chapter eleven to hand.

MONTHS 10-12

Nothing is added. You keep it up, you review the year and you reread the first ninety entries. That last exercise is the one that teaches.

THE THREE INDICATORS

- 1** Reviews filled in against spreads done. Above seventy per cent there is a practice.
- 2** Actions carried out against actions written down. It is the measure of whether the instrument is being any use.

- 3 Agreement between today's reading and the one from six months ago on the same spread. It is the measure of whether you have a method or are improvising.

AND THE WARNING FOR THE SECOND YEAR

The risk is not giving up: it is fluency. When the seventy-eight are read effortlessly, the temptation is to read fast and prettily, and there the structure starts to get in the way and gets dropped without your noticing. The warning sign is no longer counting the majors before interpreting. When you get there, go back to chapter 12 and to the review box.

CHAPTER 19

VOCABULARY

This book's terms, so that any other treatise can be read without getting lost.

A - E

ARCANUM	Each of the seventy-eight cards. Major if it belongs to the series of twenty-two; minor if it belongs to a suit.
ACE	The first card of each suit. It is not the number one: it is the pure element, before form.
CARTOMANCY	Card reading for purposes of divination. It is named here in order to distinguish it: it is not what this book teaches.
DECAN	A stretch of ten degrees of a sign. There are thirty-six, and each one corresponds to a card from two to ten.
SCALE OF NUMBER	The sequence of meanings from two to ten, common to all four suits.

F - P

COURT CARD

Page, Knight, Queen or King. Four per suit, sixteen in all.

GEMATRIA

The sum of the numerical values of the letters of a word. The twenty-two letters add up to 1,495 between them, and that figure is checked in this book.

REVERSAL

A card that comes up the wrong way round. It is read as excess, deficiency, blockage or inwardness — chosen in advance.

MARSEILLE

The French engraving pattern settled between the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. The one this book follows. Justice at VIII, Strength at XI.

NUMERAL

A card from two to ten of a suit. There are thirty-six.

SUIT

Wands, Cups, Swords or Pentacles. Each one an element and an area of life.

PROJECTIVE

An instrument whose usefulness consists in the viewer projecting their own situation onto an image that is ambiguous but bounded. It is what tarot is.

RULER OF THE DECAN

The planet that rules a stretch of ten degrees. It comes from the Chaldean order beginning at Mars.

THE 3-7-12 DIVISION

The division of the twenty-two letters into three mothers, seven doubles and twelve simples. It is from this that the majors inherit their attribution.

SPREAD

The layout of a fixed number of cards in positions with assigned meanings.

TRUMPS

The original name of the major arcana in the Italian decks of the fifteenth century. Hence «tarocchi» and «tarot».



And with that the book closes. Seventy-eight figures, twenty-two letters, thirty-six decans, four suits, three spreads and a notebook: a whole language for the same old task, which is looking at yourself with a little more precision than you have by default.

It promises nothing, and that is on purpose. What it offers is structure where there was intuition, and a notebook for checking whether the structure works. With that, anyone who really practises will find out things about themselves they did not know. And anyone who does not practise will have a handsome book, which is also a worthy fate but a different one.

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